Return of a CRIME THRILLER

Will Gaurav Shukla's ***Asur 2***, sequel to the hit web series from 2020, live up to its 'India's Biggest Crime Thriller' tag?



REIGN OF DARKNESS (from left) Anupriya Goenka, Arshad Warsi, Vishesh Bansal, Barun Sobti, Ridhi Dogra and Meiyang Chang in *Asur 2: Rise of the Dark Side*

When *Asur* arrived in early March 2020 on Voot, a new virus had wreaked havoc. For an audience holed up in their homes, the crime thriller, involving CBI officers trying to hunt down a clever, cold-blooded serial killer, became a riveting watch. The shocking end that saw a tragic death and the killer's identity revealed made viewers wait eagerly for season two. It finally comes three years later, this time on **JioCinema.**

The first episode of *Asur 2: Rise of the Dark Side*, reconnects audiences with key characters: Dhananjay Rajput a.k.a. DJ (Arshad Warsi) has taken to Buddhism and introspects over his follies with a child in Dharamsala; Nikhil (Barun Sobti), the forensic expert, is dependent on anti-depressants, while his wife, Naina (Anupriya Goenka), also a computer expert, wants a divorce. But all this is quickly forgotten as the nemesis Shubh Joshi, a.k.a. the 'Asur', is back adding to the body count. The creators are too caught up in glorifying the antagonist as the Mr Know-it-All, which, after a point, borders on the unreal.

So much so that the attributes that made him fascinating in season one now begin to feel mundane. His ability to twist Hindu scriptures and myths to justify his murderous intent is now tiring mumbo jumbo. "Ishwar can't save you," he threatens the CBI officials, who are unable to track him down even as he pops up on their screens ever so often. The astuteness with which he executed his kills now doesn't feel so compelling. But for creator Gaurav Shukla, building on Asur's enigma remains the show's focus, and one that comes at the cost of overlooking other characters and their arcs. All DJ and his gang are left to do is try to catch up with a criminal always five steps ahead.

Asur 2, playing on JioCinema, is **so caught up glorifying the antagonist** as a Mr Know-It-All that it borders on the unreal

The better portions of *Asur 2* come in the flashes of Shubh's back story revealed at the beginning of each episode. But the ability to establish his cult, one that makes his followers lose sense of right and wrong, remains unconvincing. As the cat-and-mouse game prolongs, the absurdity deepens. Even as Ashwatthama and Kalki are cited, there's mention of AI, quantum computing, dark web, deep fake videos, enzymes and data theft in Silicon Valley. So, when a character says, "I don't understand", and another remarks "*Mazaak ho raha hai* (Are you joking)?" as an 11-year-old miracle boy surfaces, it's as if they, too, are exasperated by the attempts to over-intellectualise the proceedings. Season two's key failing is that it lacks the emotional beats that made the earlier instalment one of the better crime thrillers on an OTT platform. *Asur 2* still offers a desi, ingenious take on the serial killer genre, but it may have bitten off more than it can chew. ■

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